or afternoon and evening—meant that there was barely enough time to rush back home and finish the household chores before rushing back for duty to the AIR Complex on Parliament Street. Fortunately, my mother knew how to drive, traffic was light those days and she could hold her own. As per the norm, for the early morning duty, the office car would come to pick her up and similarly to drop her back after the evening duty. It was not an easy routine. For the 8 a.m. bulletin, one had to be in the office by 5 a.m., which meant leaving home at 4.30 a.m. That was bad enough in summers and absolutely terrible in winters. Despite this, she always had time for us, had an active social life and made all my favourite things, be it puran poli (a sweet flatbread stuffed with a sweet lentil filling made from hulled and split Bengal gram/chana dal, jaggery and ground spices), or karanji (a crisp, flaky, fried, moon-shaped pastry stuffed with a sweet filling of coconut, nuts and dry fruits). Although a pure vegetarian herself—she wouldn't even eat eggs—she nevertheless would cook delicious non-vegetarian dishes for us, something she learnt during our stay in France. Later, my mother would join the Pune Station of AIR to read out the *pradeshik baatmya* (regional news) at 7.05 every morning, which she did until her retirement. A whole generation still remembers her voice, '*Sudha Naravane aaplyala pradeshik baatmya det aahet*' (the regional news, read by Sudha Naravane).

Delhi, especially Delhi Cantonment, has changed so much since those days. From DK 1, I used to walk to school, usually with my friends, the twins Lav and Kush Chand. We were in the same class from the 6th to the 9th, till I left AFCS. Lav too joined the Army, retiring as a Major General in the Corps of Signals, and was my entry into the AFCS classmates' alumni group. Ours was a co-ed school and among my classmates was a girl named Monica. At that time, a film called *Caravan*

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